



ARTICLE 43 Marquee Signs

Annual Town Meeting || April 27, 2026

*Kin Lau, Chair
Arlington Redevelopment Board*



Marquee Signs

- The Zoning Bylaw currently prohibits electronic message centers and displays. Article 43 provides a modernization path for marquee signs, such as those located at the Town's two Historic theaters, the Capital and the Regent.
- Currently, theater staff must change sign lettering manually, a task that presents a significant safety liability.
- Digital marquee technology has advanced to offer programmable LED signs that can be integrated appropriately into historic marquee facades.
- Article 43 would apply only to Marquee signs and would require applicants to obtain a Special Permit for a Marquee sign through the Redevelopment Board.





Cabot Theatre Beverly, MA

The Cabot Theatre in Beverly has installed a digital marquee sign, with the new digital display integrated into the historical marquee.

The Cabot was built in the 1920s, around the same time as both the Capitol and Regent Theatres.

Sources

Photo, Left: Paul, Leighton, *The Beverly Beat*

Photo, Right: *afterthefinalcurtain.net*





AMENDMENT TEXT

Article 43



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Amend Section 6.2.5.D.(6), as follows:

6.2.5 Standards for Permanent Signs

D. Standards for All Permanent Building-Mounted Sign Types. The following sign types are allowed, subject to the criteria listed under each sign type.

(6) Marquee Sign. Marquee signs must comply with the standards provided in the table below.

Marquee Sign Standards

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Special Provisions

Requirements

Electronic Display

- Permitted for Marquee Signs only.
- Special permit required.
- The electronic display shall be incorporated as an integral architectural component of an existing marquee and shall not be freestanding or alter the character of the marquee structure.
- Content shall be limited to the display of events, performances, or activities occurring on the premises. Off-premises advertising and general commercial advertising are prohibited.
- Displays shall be equipped with automatic dimming technology that adjusts brightness in response to ambient light conditions.
- No animated features, flashing, rotating, motion picture or application creating the illusion of motion allowed on display. See Section 6.2.3(C).

